

Medicinal Actions & Uses Now undervalued as a medicinal herb, horseradish has many healing properties. It strongly stimulates digestion, increasing gastric secretions and appetite. It is a good diuretic and promotes perspiration, making it useful in fevers, colds, and flu. It is also expectorant and mildly antibiotic, and can be of use in both respiratory and urinary tract infections. A sandwich of freshly grated root is a home remedy for hay fever. Externally, a poultice of the root can soothe chilblains.

Cautions Over-consumption of horseradish may irritate the gastrointestinal tract. The plant should be avoided by those with low thyroid function. A horseradish poultice may cause blistering.

Arnica montana (Asteraceae) Arnica

Description Aromatic perennial growing to 1 ft (30 cm). Has downy egg-shaped leaves and bright yellow daisy-like flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Arnica grows in mountain woods and pastures in central Europe, the Pyrenees, Siberia, Canada, and the northwestern U.S. Its flowers are harvested when in full bloom; the rhizomes after the plant has died back in autumn.

Parts Used Flowers, rhizome.

Constituents Arnica contains sesquiterpene lactones, flavonoids, a volatile oil that includes thymol, mucilage, and polysaccharides.

History & Folklore Arnica has been used extensively in European folk medicine. Johann Wolfgang von Goethe (1749–1832), the German philosopher and poet, drank arnica tea to ease his angina in old age.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Best known as an effective ointment and compress for bruises, sprains, and muscle pain, arnica improves the local blood supply and accelerates healing. It is anti-inflammatory and increases the rate of reabsorption of internal bleeding. Generally the plant is now taken internally only at a homeopathic dilution, principally for shock, injury, and pain. If taken as a decoction or tincture, it stimulates the circulation and is valuable in the treatment of angina and a weak or failing heart, but it can be toxic even at low dosage and thus is rarely used in this way.

Related Species In North America *A. fulgens* is used.

Cautions Do not take internally. Do not apply arnica preparations to broken skin. External use may cause dermatitis. Arnica is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Self-help Uses Bruises, p. 304; Sprains, p. 312; Tired & aching muscles, p. 312.

Artemisia abrotanum (Asteraceae) Southernwood

Description Strongly aromatic, shrubby perennial, growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has woody stems, feathery silver-green leaves, and yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southern Europe, this herb is rare in the wild but is cultivated for the perfume industry and, to a lesser extent, for herbal medicine. The aerial parts are harvested in late summer.



Southernwood leaves were traditionally placed among clothing to repel moths.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Southernwood contains a volatile oil, abrotanin, and tannins.

History & Folklore Much prized during the Middle Ages and the Renaissance, southernwood is now used infrequently in herbal medicine.

The closely related wormwood (*A. absinthium*, p. 66) is considered superior. Like wormwood, southernwood contains a strong volatile oil that repels insects, and the leaves are placed among clothes to repel moths. Mrs. Grieve (*A Modern Herbal*, 1931) reports that in England "even in the early part of the last century a bunch of southernwood and rue [*Ruta graveolens*, p. 265] was placed next to the prisoner in the dock as a preventive from the contagion of jail fever."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Southernwood is a bitter tonic. It strengthens and supports digestive function by increasing secretions in the stomach and intestines. An infusion of southernwood has been given to children as a treatment for worms, but this is not recommended without professional supervision. Like other *Artemisias*, southernwood stimulates menstruation and is commonly taken to encourage the onset of irregular or absent periods.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy. Not suitable for children under 12 unless prescribed professionally.

Artemisia capillaris (Asteraceae) Yin Chen Hao

Description Medium-sized perennial herb with an erect stem, thin feathery leaves, and clusters of small composite flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Southeast Asia, *yin chen hao* is cultivated in China and other Far Eastern countries. The young plants are gathered in spring.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents *Yin chen hao* contains a volatile oil and coumarins. The volatile oil is antifungal.

History & Folklore *Yin chen hao* has been used in Chinese herbal medicine for more than 2,000 years. Its medicinal properties were first listed in *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'ong Bencaojing*), written in the 1st century CE.

Medicinal Actions & Uses *Yin chen hao* is an effective remedy for liver problems, being specifically helpful for treating hepatitis with jaundice. Traditional Chinese medicine (see pp. 40–43) holds that it is bitter and cooling, clearing "damp heat" from the liver and gall ducts and relieving fevers. *Yin chen hao* is also anti-inflammatory and diuretic. It was formerly applied in the form of a plaster to treat headaches.

Research Investigation undertaken in China indicates that like many *Artemisia* species, *yin chen hao* has a tonic and strengthening effect on the liver, gallbladder, and digestive system.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy. Unsuitable for children under 12 unless prescribed professionally.

Artemisia cina (Asteraceae) Levant Wormwood

Description Shrubby perennial with long thin leaves and tiny round tufts of flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation This herb is native to the region stretching from the eastern Mediterranean to Siberia. The unopened flower heads are gathered from wild and cultivated plants.

Parts Used Flower heads.

Constituents Levant wormwood contains santonin (a sesquiterpene lactone), artemisin, and a volatile oil (with up to 80% cineole). Santonin is directly toxic to roundworms and, to a lesser extent, threadworms.

History & Folklore Levant wormwood was known to the classical Greek world as a remedy for intestinal worms, and it has been used for this